

vertigo

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

NO. 631 February 2001 P O B O X 1 6 2 8 W E L L I N G T O N

Club nights are at Turnbull House,¹ where new and prospective members are welcome. Meet for dinner at the Backbencher² at 6.30 and on to Turnbull House at 7.30 for a catch up. Meetings, run with an iron fist jam in a velvet glove by Alan Lowrie, start with precision at 8.00 with club business. The talk starts bloody soon afterwards.

Club Nights



Phantom January section night – get over it!

No-one has not been confirmed for the January section night. Go climbing. Get some extra sleep. Read "War and Peace". Or something.



February section night on 12th of February

Since you're all out of town on Monday 5 February to get in the 4 day weekend, the Grand Central and All Powerful Committee decree that there will be a BBQ night at Fergs Rock 'n Kayak, Shed 6, Queens Wharf on Monday 12 February. Cashless climbing on production of your membership card. Free fizz 'n snags as well as the obligatory white sandwich bread and lashings of Watties' finest vintage red. Beer will be available but only for those having finished climbing. "We", according to the all powerful voice behind the All Powerful Committee, "discourage drinking and climbing but not climbing and drinking".

And next month the section night will feature the amazing highlights of the incredible Snow Lake trip into the Karakoram ranges. A group presentation bought to you by the Alpine club of Wellington.



Yes, it's the Baring Head Rock Hop again!

Fun times at Baring Head on Saturday 17th of February with the Annual Bouldering Rock Hop, the second event in the National Bouldering Series. A primo occasion for the experienced as well as beginners and first timers. Can't wait. We suggest you go. All other details in the flier, contained herein. See also www.powerband.org.nz for details of the National Bouldering Series, sponsored by Bivouac.



Great Bowen street statue challenge

Late last year the Ed. and Spitto had an enjoyable evening's bouldering around town. The boulders outside Te Papa are reported to be more fun than Kylie Minogue. However, on to the real point. At the bottom of Bowen Street behind Parliament are three statues, funner than the Fun Boy Three (name check obscure 80s pop band). One - "The Carrot" - awaits a first ascent. The Ed. hereby offers a crisp new \$20 note for the first free ascent by some local strong woman or man (photographic evidence and trip report mandatory).



¹ Clashed behind the Treasury on number 1 the Terrace. On Bowen Street.

² On Molesworth Street, opposite Parliament.

Welly High Wall Tuesday night

This wall will be open to Alpine Club members on Tuesdays from 7 pm. There is bouldering, top ropes, table tennis to warm up on, crash mats, and a CD machine. Bring your own music! It has a range of climbs and boulder problems from **Easy** to **Fing** hard. Call Scotty Taylor if you want to know more. \$5 gets you entry. Ring Scott before going to make sure its happening.



NZAC Night at Fergs Monday February 19th

Fergs charge only \$5 for NZAC members on club nights – bring your membership card. Fergs charge \$8 for members on other nights, on production of card. Fergs are only \$5 for the Methusalahs amongst us. Reasons to live, or what?



Hangdog discount

Hangdog no longer have a cheap night on the second Monday of the month but they have matched Fergs \$8 discount to club members, down from \$9 last year. Remember your card!



Editor's Bit

I received the following comment on December's editorial piece. The wife of the sender has understandably asked that his name remain anonymous. I respect Deborah's wishes.

"As for mountaineering being like war - rubbish. Its just like sex - very physical, reading about it heightens the desire, smelly afterwards, good for the soul, huge risks if you do it with the wrong people, don't want to do any more for about 5 mins after you've finished then want to get into it again, and I'm not even going to get into the subject of mountains as phallic symbols".

Interesting thoughts. Next month, I will discourse about early first ascents in human history and the whole "Mungo Man" furore.



Wellington Section News

Excellent news coming through. Thanks people! But more still needed from your Christmas and post-Christmas trips, gross und klein, as Wolfgang Gullich would have said. And how about someone telling me what happened on the summer camp?

Cooking up romance

Under the tutelage of one of their former instructors Pete de Joux, four AIC 2000 alumni met at Unwin Hut on 2 December for a week of climbing in the Mt.Cook area. With fair weather on Sunday, Pete, Kirsten Gray, Dylan Mackenzie, Geoff Leech and Edward McConnaughey flew aboard a Porter ski-plane to Cornice Wall on the Tasman Glacier and set up base camp in the Tasman Saddle Hut. The good weather continued on Monday and the team climbed Aylmer and Hochstetter Dome.

The team made an early start on Tuesday for an attempt on Elie de Beaumont. After crossing several dodgy snow bridges and ascending to near the top of Anna Glacier, they encountered difficult ice conditions on a steep slope and decided to abort the summit attempt. God confirmed that this was the correct decision by causing Pete's unsecured helmet to slide several hundred metres down the glacier.

High winds on Wednesday precluded any summit attempts, and the day was spent practicing ice climbing techniques on the seracs below Tasman Saddle Hut. A frontal system passed through the area on Thursday, keeping everyone hut-bound except for "Caveman Dylan". Displaying an exceptional amount of romanticism for a Kiwi bloke; the Caveman dug a two-person snow cave on a slope above the

hut, etched a large heart on the entrance shelf with the appropriate "DM + KG" inscription, and enticed "the Princess" to join him for an overnight snow cave bivy. The frugal couple emerged the next morning expressing much satisfaction having saved \$36 in DOC hut fees.

The fair weather returned on Friday and the team flew back to Mt.Cook Village. Kirsten and Dylan returned to Wellington and Geoff, Pete and Ed remained to make guided attempts on Mt.Cook.

Well dung, Yakking round the fire: early season trekking in the Khumbu

In mid-September I (Ed Mconnaughey, well known to those who were at the January 2000 NZAC climbing camp at the Bay), met up with my son John in Delhi and, after a trip to the Taj Mahaj, flew to Kathmandu to begin a five week trekking visit to the Khumbu Region of Nepal. The Khumbu Region, inhabited mostly by Sherpas who have migrated from Tibet, is immediately south of Mt. Everest, is the second most popular trekking area in Nepal after Annapurna. To avoid crowds, John and I decided to start our independent trek several weeks before the traditional post-monsoon trekking season in an effort to avoid the groups and associated crowding. On 19 September, they flew into Phaplu then trekked four days to reach Namche Bazaar in time for the Saturday market where Nepalese and Tibetans engage in a flurry of trading. During our hike in, it rained three afternoons - the only daytime rain during the trek.

From Namche, we explored the four major high altitude trekking routes into the Himalayas - Thames, Lobuche, Chukhung and Gokyo; remaining between 3500 and 5500 meters elevation for three weeks before returning to Namche and on to Lukla for the return flight to Kathmandu.

Highlights of the trek were: the ascents of Kala Pattar, Chukhung Ri and Gokyo Ri, with the associated views of the top-of-the-World peaks; the hike in and visit to the Mt. Everest Base Camp where we were hosted by the Slovenian Expedition and met Davo Kernicar who several days later climbed Mt. Everest then skied back down to the Base Camp; and the many hours keeping warm around a yak-dung fire while chatting with our Sherpa hosts and other tea house guests.

During the first two weeks, we shared the trails with Sherpa porters and yaks transporting supplies, a few independent trekkers, and two climbing expeditions. We didn't encounter our first trekking group until the 4th of October while on our way down from Lobuche - twelve foreigners, 20+ porters and 5 yaks strung out on the trail for over a kilometer! Within a week, the main trails connecting Namche with Gokyo and Lobuche were crowded with a constant flow of group trekkers and their baggage trains. When we flew out of Lukla on the 16th, group trekkers were arriving at a rate of 200+ per day.

Our packs weighed in at less than 14 kilos each, so were no problem to carry. However, about half the independent trekkers did use porters, and about half of those also used guides. If you are fit and can read a map, there is no need for either. We stayed at Sherpa-run tea houses each night. Accommodation costs were between \$3 and \$4 NZ for a double room. You are expected to eat dinner and breakfast at the lodge. The menu typically had a variety of noodle, rice, potato and egg dishes; but very little vegetables, fruits and meat. Daily meal costs averaged about \$12NZ per person.

The early start on the trekking season worked out well. We shared the Himalayas with the Sherpas and a few foreigners for the first few weeks. I'm tempted to say we should have started a few weeks earlier; but it's a gamble as to when the monsoon season will end each year. And, as Kiwis know, hiking all day in a cold rain is no fun.

Thanks to Ed.

Some still Aspiring

Four teams from Wellington headed to Wanaka in late December to attempt to climb Mt Aspiring. Andrew Johnston (actually from Rangiora) and Blair Lesley and Stephen Meickle and Dan Meickle summited.

Andrew and Blair had an article in the ODT devoted to them for the first ascent of Aspiring in 2001. The reason for the honour must have been the vast empty news spaces in the January pages. In other

words, 2001, a space ODT. Fnarr, fnarr ...

The Matt Stevens & Alan Lowrie and Chris Bayless & Diana Munster Aspirants are planning a another attempt next year after suffering a LMF (lack of moral fortitude) problem and turning back early.

VertiGO recommends "One night in Bangkok"

Debs and Mike spent 3 weeks in Thailand late last year and didn't hang round in Bangkok. They headed north to go trekking - a good way to acclimatise to the heat. The balance was spent rock climbing at Rai Ley. Not many climbs below 18 so the training Mike did prior to going was well rewarded, and the training that Deb chose not to do was also well rewarded. Plenty of stuff to do on rest days - laze on the beach, snorkelling or diving, jungle walks or eating yourself to a standstill on the superb Thai cuisine. Tips for prospective visitors: 1) Climb Stagalarus and Groove Tube. 2) Buy 20 litre water canisters at Hot Rock 3). spend no more than one night in Bangkok. 4) There is no four. 5) take loads of sunblock and basic supplies into Rai Leh if you are going to be there for a while and 6) don't go to Rai Leh in October - it's the wettest month of the year.

Tiddly smidgeons

Kath Brownlie is off to Thailand and parts further flung. Bon climbing!

A number of new routes going up on the Plateau at Whanganui Bay from Phil Castle and others. A good turnout of Wellington climbers over the Anniversary weekend too. The new lower car park has made access to camping even easier. Grab some of the pine cones littered around after the logging action up the access road on your way down and have a decent fire!

Tobias Johnston, Mikhail von Geldern and Glynn Hodgers attempted Sefton from the west - no news yet from these pointless excuses for humanity.

The Ed., accompanied by notorious rock artiste Fleur Ascent, climbed in Sydney at Lindfield (super), bouldered at Middle Cove (worthwhile) and at Palm Beach (golden sandy landings). Raids were also made on Mt Piddington in the Bluies (snake scares) and Nowra.



e-Vertigo reminder

If you wish to receive Vertigo by email, please send an email to vertigo_newsletter_subscribe@egroups.com. It can be viewed on the web at nzalpine.wellington.net.nz.



Trips: This club needs you!!!

If you truly do think you have the nous. To lead at trip to your favourite mountain for some less experienced but keen and eager people. Who want to get out and about into the snow and rock and ice. Especially if it is a weekend or long weekend sort of jaunt. You! You are enjoined to contact our trips person. Or the inter-acting all powerful chair personage.

I promise to come along and lend my extensive inexperience to the cause.



Wellington Section Directory

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